

### A practical field guide to tent, vehicle, RV, trailer, cabin, public-land and long-term campground living

**PURPOSE.** This guide is for people considering camping as short-term or transitional housing. It focuses on finding legal places to stay, understanding the real cost, choosing the right camping method, and avoiding the mistake of assuming that every campground or piece of public land permits long-term residence.

**IMPORTANT.** Camping, overnight-parking, residency, fire, sanitation and maximum-stay rules vary by land manager and location. Always verify the exact rules for the site before traveling. Public land is not automatically legal to camp on, and most federal dispersed camping is intended for temporary recreational use rather than permanent residence.

#### 1. CHOOSE THE TYPE OF CAMPING THAT FITS YOUR SITUATION

##### Tent camping

Usually the lowest-cost developed-campground option. A basic setup can work without a vehicle if the campground is reachable, but weather, food storage, charging, transportation and security matter.

##### Car camping

Sleeping inside a legally parked vehicle. It can eliminate the cost of a tent, but overnight-parking and vehicle-habitation rules vary by city, campground and property.

##### Van or SUV camping

Similar to car camping but generally easier for sleeping and storage. Campground rules may classify the vehicle differently depending on hookups and site type.

##### RV or motorhome camping

Provides shelter and often a kitchen/bathroom, but adds fuel, maintenance, registration, insurance and campsite costs. Full-hookup sites usually cost more than primitive or electric-only sites.

##### Travel trailer / camper

Can provide inexpensive housing if already owned, but towing and setup are major barriers. Some private parks rent stationary campers or trailers already placed on a site.

##### Campground cabin

Useful for someone arriving without camping equipment. Cabins range from primitive sleeping cabins with shared bathrooms to units with kitchens, bathrooms, heat/AC and Wi-Fi.

##### Yurt / platform tent / rustic shelter

A middle ground between tent and cabin. These can be economical off-season but tourist-oriented glamping units may cost more than a motel.

##### Long-term campground / RV park

Some private parks sell weekly, monthly or seasonal stays. These can be far cheaper than paying the nightly rate for 30 days, but may have deposits, background checks, RV-age rules or limits on children.

##### Work camping / campground hosting

Some public and private campgrounds exchange labor for a campsite, hookups, housing, wages or a combination. Search for campground host, workamping, resident host and seasonal campground jobs.

#### 2. REALISTIC COST LADDER

These are broad planning ranges, not guaranteed prices. Actual prices vary enormously by region, season, amenities and length of stay.

| Type                          | Planning range                      | What to expect                                                                         |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dispersed public-land camping | Often \$0                           | Usually no utilities, bathrooms, trash service or Wi-Fi; strict stay limits may apply. |
| Basic public tent site        | Often about \$10-\$30/night         | May include a designated site, fire ring, toilets and sometimes potable water.         |
| Developed public campground   | Often about \$20-\$50/night         | More amenities; reservations and additional fees may apply.                            |
| Private tent site             | Often about \$25-\$60+/night        | Amenities vary; weekly rates may be negotiable.                                        |
| RV site                       | Often about \$35-\$80+/night        | Electric/water/full hookups change the price.                                          |
| Monthly RV/campsite           | Often roughly \$400-\$1,200+        | Can be much cheaper than nightly pricing; utilities may be extra.                      |
| Primitive/basic cabin         | Often roughly \$30-\$100+ per night | May only include beds/electricity and shared bath facilities.                          |
| Developed cabin               | Often roughly \$60-\$150+ per night | May include bathroom/kitchen/heat /AC; monthly discounts vary.                         |

**Do not compare only the advertised site price. Calculate:** site + reservation fees + electricity + showers + laundry + propane/fuel + internet + transportation + food storage + required deposits.

### 3. NATIONAL CAMPGROUND & CABIN FINDERS

**Recreation.gov:** Federal reservation/search system for participating federal campgrounds, RV sites, cabins, yurts and other recreation facilities. Fees are set by the participating agencies and vary by location. [Open website](#)

**National Park Service Camping:** Official NPS starting point for campground information and park-specific rules. [Open website](#)

**U.S. Forest Service:** Search National Forest recreation areas, developed campgrounds, cabins and information about dispersed camping. [Open website](#)

**Bureau of Land Management Camping:** Official information on BLM developed and dispersed camping, especially useful in western states. [Open website](#)

**ReserveAmerica:** Reservation platform used by many state and local park systems. Search by state, destination and accommodation type. [Open website](#)

**KOA:** Private nationwide campground network offering combinations of tent sites, RV sites and cabins. Usually not the cheapest option, but useful for comparing all three accommodation types in one place. [Open website](#)

**Hipcamp:** Marketplace for campsites and accommodations on private land, including tent sites, RV spots, cabins, yurts and unusual stays. Always read host rules and total fees carefully. [Open website](#)

### 4. FREE & DISPERSED CAMPING

Dispersed camping means camping outside a developed campground on land where the managing agency permits it. It can be free, but it usually provides no services. Expect no shower, electricity, Wi-Fi, trash pickup, picnic table or potable water unless a particular site says otherwise.

**BLM rule of thumb:** Most BLM lands allow dispersed camping unless closed or restricted. BLM says dispersed stays are generally limited to 14 days within a 28-day period, but local field-office rules can differ. BLM also states that dispersed camping is for short-term recreational use, not long-term living, except for designated Long-Term Visitor Areas.

#### [BLM Camping & Dispersed Camping](#)

National Forest rules also vary by forest and ranger district. Some forests permit dispersed camping broadly; others restrict areas, require permits or impose special fire and stay rules. Check the specific National Forest page before traveling.

#### [U.S. Forest Service Camping](#)

Examples of BLM locations with no camping fee exist in Arizona, New Mexico, Oregon, Utah and Washington, but many are remote and may require high-clearance vehicles. Free does not necessarily mean accessible or practical.

### 5. HOW TO FIND LONG-TERM OR MONTHLY CAMPGROUNDS

Private campgrounds and RV parks are the main place to look for stays measured in weeks or months. Their monthly price is often not displayed on booking sites.

monthly RV park

long-term campground

extended-stay RV park

monthly campsite

seasonal campground

primitive camping monthly

campground cabin monthly

long-term cabin campground

resident campground

work camping / workamping

Add the city, county or state to each search. Call independently owned parks and ask for the lowest weekly or monthly rate. A park advertising \$45 per night may have a completely different monthly price.

## 6. QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE PAYING

What is your cheapest weekly rate?

What is your cheapest monthly or seasonal rate?

What is the total amount required at check-in?

Are taxes included in that quote?

Is electricity included or separately metered?

Is Wi-Fi included, and does it reach the campsite/cabin?

Are showers included?

Is laundry available and what does it cost?

Do you allow tents for extended stays?

Do you rent cabins?

Do you rent stationary campers or trailers already on-site?

Are children permitted for extended stays?

What is the maximum stay?

Is there a deposit, credit check or background check?

Do you require an RV to be newer than a certain model year?

Can residents receive mail or packages?

Is potable water available?

How far away are groceries, pharmacy and a laundromat?

Is public transportation available?

Do you have campground-host, maintenance or work-exchange positions?

What happens during severe weather or campground evacuation?

## 7. TENT CAMPING: MINIMUM PRACTICAL SETUP

For transitional living, prioritize survival and weather protection over recreational gear.

Weather-appropriate tent with intact rain fly

Ground tarp or footprint

Sleeping pad or insulating layer

Sleeping bag/blankets appropriate to nighttime temperature

Flashlight/headlamp and backup batteries

Water containers and confirmed potable-water source

Food stored according to campground/wildlife rules

Phone charging plan: electrical outlet, power bank or approved charging location

Rain protection for documents/electronics

Basic first-aid supplies

Hygiene plan: campground shower, gym, truck stop or other legal facility

Laundry plan

Emergency weather plan

Never use charcoal grills, camp stoves, propane heaters or generators inside a closed tent. Carbon monoxide can kill without warning.

## 8. CAR / VAN / SUV CAMPING

Vehicle camping works only where overnight parking and sleeping are permitted. Permission to park does not automatically mean permission to camp.

Verify overnight-parking rules before settling in.

Never sleep with the engine running in an enclosed or poorly ventilated area.

Do not use fuel-burning heaters or cooking appliances inside a closed vehicle.

Plan for extreme heat and cold; a parked vehicle can become dangerous quickly.

Keep the driver's area usable in case you must leave.

Know where legal bathrooms and potable water are available.

Avoid accumulating belongings outside the vehicle where that converts parking into prohibited camping.

If using a campground, confirm whether the site accepts ordinary passenger vehicles for overnight sleeping.

## 9. RVs, TRAILERS & STATIONARY CAMPERS

An RV can solve shelter, kitchen and storage problems, but buying one is not automatically a cheap-housing solution. Budget for purchase or rental, insurance, registration, repairs, fuel, towing, propane, dump fees and the campsite itself.

If you do not own a tow vehicle, search for a camper or trailer that is already placed on private land or inside a campground. Ask whether the unit itself and the site are rented together. This can provide RV-style housing without purchasing or towing an RV.

Understand hookup terminology: NO HOOKUPS = self-contained/primitive; ELECTRIC = power only; WATER/ELECTRIC = both; FULL HOOKUPS = electric, water and sewer at the site. Confirm amperage (commonly 30A or 50A) before booking an RV site.

## 10. CABIN STAYS

Campground cabins can be especially useful for someone who has no vehicle, tent or RV. Do not assume 'cabin' means a furnished house.

Primitive sleeping cabin: usually beds/bunks and shelter; bathroom may be shared.

Electric cabin: may add lights, outlets, heat or AC.

Deluxe cabin: may include bathroom, refrigerator and cooking facilities.

Park cabin/yurt: often managed through a state or federal park reservation system.

Private campground cabin: may have weekly/off-season discounts that are not advertised online.

Ask what bedding, cookware, towels, refrigerator, heating/AC, bathroom, Wi-Fi and electricity are actually included before arriving.

## 11. CAMPING WITH CHILDREN

For a parent or caregiver, the cheapest campsite is not necessarily the cheapest workable campsite. Prioritize sanitation, water, weather safety, communication and access to ordinary services.

24-hour bathroom access

Safe potable water

Reliable way to refrigerate/store food

Electricity or charging access

Cellular signal and/or Wi-Fi

Distance to groceries and pharmacy

Laundry access

Library or other indoor daytime space nearby

Severe-weather shelter

Maximum-stay rules

School/homeschool internet needs

Whether the campground permits children during long-term stays

## 12. WORK CAMPING / CAMPGROUND HOSTING

Workamping is a broad term for arrangements where someone works at or around a campground, RV park, resort or recreation site in exchange for wages, a campsite, hookups, housing, or some combination.

Search terms: campground host, work camper, workamping, resident campground host, RV park maintenance, campground front desk, seasonal resort housing, park host, groundskeeper with housing.

Before accepting, ask exactly how many hours are required, whether the campsite/housing is considered taxable compensation, whether utilities are included, whether wages are paid in addition to the site, whether children are permitted, and what happens to housing if the job ends.

## 13. IF YOU ARE ARRIVING WITH ALMOST NOTHING

Choose the option by what you already possess. Do not spend hundreds or thousands of dollars buying equipment simply to qualify for a supposedly cheap housing method.

|                      |                           |
|----------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>What you have</b> | <b>Start by searching</b> |
|----------------------|---------------------------|

|                                          |                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Backpack / no vehicle</b>             | <b>Cabin, hostel-like campground lodging, work-exchange housing, or campground reachable by transit.</b>  |
| <b>Tent but no vehicle</b>               | <b>Walk-in/transit-accessible tent campground, state/local park near a town, or private land camping.</b> |
| <b>Car/SUV/van</b>                       | <b>Legal vehicle campground, private campground, or permitted overnight sites.</b>                        |
| <b>RV</b>                                | <b>Monthly RV parks, seasonal sites, workamping and public campgrounds for shorter stays.</b>             |
| <b>Travel trailer but no tow vehicle</b> | <b>Stationary placement, local towing service, or long-term park where the trailer can remain.</b>        |
| <b>Nothing but ability to work</b>       | <b>Campground host, resident caretaker, seasonal resort/campground job or work exchange.</b>              |

#### 14. THE LANDING-ZONE TEST

Before traveling to a cheap campground, map the actual distance between the campsite and the things required to live. A remote \$300/month site can cost more than a \$600 site near town if every grocery trip requires an expensive ride.

Campground / cabin

Intercity bus or train stop

Grocery store

Pharmacy

Laundromat

Library

Public transit stop

Medical care

Reliable cellular coverage

Emergency severe-weather shelter

## 15. QUICK NATIONAL STARTING POINTS

**Federal campground/cabin search:** [Recreation.gov](https://www.recreation.gov)

**National Forest camping:** [U.S. Forest Service](https://www.fs.fed.us)

**BLM camping/free dispersed options:** [Bureau of Land Management](https://www.blm.gov)

**National parks:** [National Park Service](https://www.nps.gov)

**State/local park reservations:** [ReserveAmerica](https://www.reserveamerica.com)

**Private land camping/cabins:** [Hipcamp](https://www.hipcamp.com)

**Private tent/RV/cabin network:** [KOA](https://www.koa.com)

## 16. FINAL RULE: VERIFY BEFORE YOU MOVE

A campground listing can be technically accurate and still be unusable as temporary housing. Before spending transportation money, call or message the property and verify the rate, availability, maximum stay, child policy, utilities, transportation access and exact amount required on arrival. For public land, verify the current land-manager rules, closures, fire restrictions and stay limit.

Federal dispersed camping can provide extremely low-cost short stays, but it generally should be treated as a temporary bridge rather than permanent housing. For stays measured in months, private monthly campgrounds, RV parks, campground cabins, stationary camper rentals and work-camping arrangements are usually the categories to investigate first.

Sources / Official Starting Points

[Recreation.gov reservation policies and fee information](https://www.recreation.gov/reservation/policies-and-fee-information)

[Bureau of Land Management camping and dispersed-camping rules](https://www.blm.gov/camping-and-dispersed-camping-rules)

[National Park Service camping](https://www.nps.gov/camping)

[U.S. Forest Service camping](https://www.fs.fed.us/camping)